

resigned under a cloud, so perhaps they're calling it something else now.)

Did I mention that Merrill Lynch brokers are now known as "financial consultants"? There's been a drift in this direction since Shearson Lehman first called its brokers "financial planners." Before that, they were "account executives" or "registered representatives." "Customers' men" takes us back to the 1920s. From "customers' men" to "financial consultant" you'll notice an elevation in stature, to which stockbrokers are no less entitled than prison wardens who've become "behavioral scientists," physical education teachers who are "sports therapists," and ushers who are "crowd engineers."

The dialogues they practiced so hard prepared them for "consultative selling." If you've been cold-called in the last few months, you'll have noticed it. The new broker, a.k.a. financial consultant, doesn't seem to be trying to sell anything. He seems content to sit on the telephone and chat about financial goals. "*When's he going to give the pitch?*" you may have wondered, but he never does. Even if you tell him you've been dying to buy IBM, he'll discourage it until you've come down to the office and reviewed your financial objectives.

As one of the training directors explained it: "In the old days, the sales-oriented broker would say things like, 'IBM is poised for a move, and we at Merrill Lynch think you should pick up 100 shares.' Now, the financial consultant says, 'Mr. Client, what is your most pressing concern?' "

This gets the prospective client into the office with a complete list of assets, since the "financial consultant" has to know your assets before your objectives can be reviewed. From there, he may offer you a loan from the loan department, insurance from the insurance department, real estate from the real estate department. Ultimately, the purpose of not selling anything is to sell a great deal more, which is the zen aspect of the consultative approach.

Another advantage of consultative selling is that the financial consultant becomes an expert in the client's needs. This, I can see, is much smarter than posing as an expert in the stock market. Even when he makes bad investment decisions, the financial consultant is still an expert in the client's needs, which presumably will be